

*Falco tinnunculus*

Common kestrel



Length 12½–15½ in  
(32–39 cm)

Weight 4–12 oz  
(125–325 g)

Plumage Sexes differ

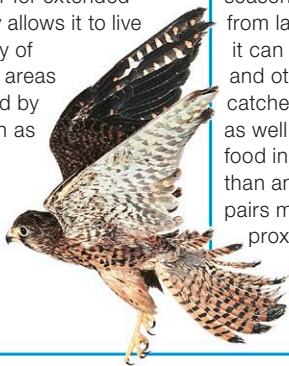
Migration Partial migrant

Status Least concern

Location Europe, Asia, Africa



The common kestrel is a small, chestnut-brown falcon with a black-tipped tail as well as black bars and spots. It is one of the few medium-sized birds that can hover for extended periods. This ability allows it to live and hunt in a variety of habitats, especially areas not often frequented by other species, such as the edges of major roads. Its diet consists mainly of small mammals (including voles and mice), insects, and amphibians.



*Falco rusticolus*

Gyr falcon



Length 19–26 in  
(48–65 cm)

Weight 1¼–4½ lb  
(0.8–2.1 kg)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Migratory

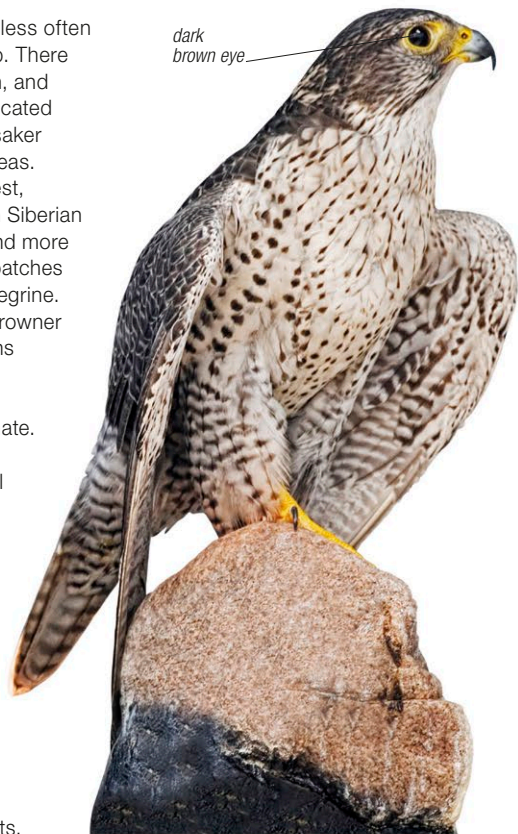
Status Least concern

Location Subarctic



The biggest of all falcons, the gyrfalcon breeds in subarctic regions, mostly in extensive tundra with cliff faces on which it can nest. Outside the breeding season, it may rest on sea ice far from land, close to open water where it can find prey, such as ducks, gulls, and other seabirds. In summer, it catches birds of almost any size, as well as lemmings and hares. Its food includes many more mammals than any other falcon, but breeding pairs may rely more on the close proximity of large seabird colonies, or healthy populations of grouse and ptarmigans. Prey is typically taken close to the

ground, in a low, fast chase, less often in a fast, peregrine-like stoop. There are several forms of gyrfalcon, and identification is further complicated by hybrids between gyr and saker falcons appearing in some areas. Greenland birds are the whitest, while Scandinavian and north Siberian birds are noticeably darker and more “hooded,” with darker facial patches approaching those of the peregrine. Young birds are darker and browner still. In the far north, gyrfalcons are usually safe from human disturbance, but they are threatened by a warming climate. Historically, local populations have been damaged by illegal theft and smuggling of young birds for falconry. Few move far south in the winter, but they may be encountered across Canada and more rarely in northwestern Europe, when solitary birds appear in open mountain, moorland, or coastal districts. Races of gyrfalcons vary from lead-gray to almost pure, white birds with fine dark spots.



*Falco eleonora*

Eleonora’s falcon



Length 14–16½ in  
(36–42 cm)

Weight 13–14 oz  
(350–400 g)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Migrant

Status Least concern

Location S. Europe, N. and E. Africa, Madagascar



This fairly small falcon has the typical streamlined falcon shape, but its wings are longer and more swiftlike. It has 2 color forms—normal and melanistic. The normal plumage is dark above and cream with flecks below, while the melanistic form is dark all over. This bird breeds in autumn, usually on cliffs of remote islands, feeding mainly on small birds.

*Falco columbarius*

Merlin



Length 10–13 in  
(24–33 cm)

Weight 6–8 oz  
(165–230 g)

Plumage Sexes differ

Migration Migratory

Status Least concern

Location North America, Eurasia



The merlin is a small, compact, fast-flying falcon of open countryside, especially heather moorland with scattered trees in summer, and extensive coastal marshland or pastureland in winter. On moorland, it may nest on the ground, or appropriate an old tree nest of a crow. Ground-nesters, especially, are quiet

and inconspicuous, but males may perch nearby, calling to warn incubating females of possible danger. Their eggs are typical of the falcons, richly colored with smears and mottles of rusty brown. Merlins are almost exclusively bird-eaters. They do not have the dramatic stoops of a



peregrine, but chase down prey in fast, twisting pursuits, rising and falling until the small bird, such as a pipit or finch, is tired. Males are smaller than females, and on average hunt smaller birds, allowing pairs to coexist in smaller home ranges. Between such hunts, merlins spend much of their time perched on a low eminence such as a rock, post, or even clump of earth, where they are easily overlooked. Over their very wide range, merlins have evolved into many subspecies, those from more northerly regions being more migratory and tending to be larger and paler. The male is smooth blue-gray and orange buff, but females are earth-brown.

*Falco peregrinus*

Peregrine falcon



Length 13½–20 in  
(34–50 cm)

Weight 1¼–3¼ lb  
(0.55–1.5 kg)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Partial migrant

Status Least concern

Location Worldwide (except Antarctica)



The peregrine falcon is one of the world’s fastest birds. It also has the widest distribution of any day-flying land bird, being found on every continent, except Antarctica, and

on many oceanic islands. Females can be up to 30 percent larger than males. The bird’s wings have sharply pointed tips, making them both fast and highly maneuverable; it flies largely by flapping rather than soaring. This falcon usually attacks its prey in a steep, powerful dive, or stoop, during which it may reach a speed of 145 mph (230 kph). Courtship involves aerial displays accompanied by noisy calling. The peregrine falcon has been used in falconry for centuries. In the 1950s and 60s, it was badly affected by DDT pollution, particularly in Europe and the USA, but it is now staging a gradual recovery.

AERIAL PURSUIT



The peregrine falcon may chase its prey—especially doves and pigeons—in order to exhaust them quickly. It usually strikes the prey with its talons, and then follows it to the ground.

PLUMAGE

This falcon has white to cream to rufous underparts, and black, gray, or blue upperparts. The young are brown with buff edging on contour feathers, and vertical stripes on the breast.

